

Group-level phenomena in multi-agent systems


Humans


MARL
agents


LLM
agents

 Documented in the wild

WHAT AGENT GROUPS BUILD

Emergent communication & language				
Conventions & coordination				
Social structure: networks, hierarchy, roles				 Multi-agent “turf wars” (2026)
Culture, norms & individuality				
Collective intelligence & performance				
Emergent economy & resource use				
Spontaneous cooperation				

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Conformity & collective bias				
Collusion, deception & manipulation				 Agents collude to bypass guardrails (2026)  Hidden message board to cheat an eval (2026)  Agents turned against each other (2025)
Emergent harm: toxicity, fragility, breakout				 Agents breach production infrastructure (2026)  Agents hijack a live website (2026)  AI-orchestrated espionage campaign (2025)